



## DELHI | Civil Equality

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of the 166 women who qualified the Civil Services Examination finished in the top 25 list of successful candidates.

Is Indian bureaucracy to get a kinder, gentler and, may we hope, more efficient face? At least they've given themselves a shot this year when for the first time the top three positions in the Civil Services Examination 2008 were bagged by women. Shubhra Saxena, Sharandeep Kaur Brar and Kiran Kaushal are the podium finishers, with a total of 10 women in the top 25 candidates.

It may still be less than half but is an unprecedented percentage nevertheless. The overall percentages are still heavily skewed in favour of men, with 625 of the 791 successful candidates men and 166 women. Women, though, are inching their way up, and many observers believe that the ratio may well be reversed. Category-wise, 364 are general candidates, including 13 physically challenged persons, 236 are from Other Backward Classes (including seven physically challenged), 130 are Scheduled Castes and 61 are Scheduled Tribes candidates. Incidentally, the topper among men, Varinder Kumar Sharma, who ranked fourth, is a physically challenged candidate. The Civil Services still remain one of the most sought after careers in the country, among both men and women. A staggering number of 3,18,843 candidates had applied for the examination, and of the 1,67,035 who took the preliminary examination, only 11,849 made it to the mains. From these, 2,140 were selected for the personality test, where women flew high.

by Bhavna Vij-Aurora

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THE LAL BAHADUR SHASTRI ACADEMY (TOP) IN MUSSOORIE